



God decides to
bring about the
existence of
contingent things

And this fact must be necessary, or contingent.

If it is necessary, then, again, premise (1) of initial argument is false.

And if it is contingent, then by the PSR it must have some explanation. But what could this be?

This is a complex line of thought. Here's a different way to get at basically the same point.

It seems that for any two contingent facts, we can consider their
conjunction.

So, for example, if we start with the contingent facts

Notre Dame is in Indiana.

USC is in California.

We can also consider the conjunctive fact

Notre Dame is in Indiana and USC is in California.

It looks like we can also do this for arbitrarily long lists of contingent facts: 3 facts, 10 facts, 1 million facts, etc.

So now consider the the very big conjunctive fact C , which is the conjunction of all of the contingent facts that there are.

We know that C will be contingent. So, if the PSR is true, C has an explanation. Let's call this explanation "E."

Here's a plausible claim: no conjunctive facts can be explained by one of the facts that make it up. It would not make much sense to say that the reason why Notre Dame is in Indiana and USC is in California is that Notre Dame is in Indiana.

But C contains all of the contingent facts. So E must be necessary.

But here is another plausible claim: no necessary truth can ever explain a contingent truth. A necessary truth is something which is true no matter how the world turns out to be. So how could it explain some contingent fact about the world?

So we appear to have reached a contradiction. What is going on?

One way to think about the line of thought we have just pursued is that it shows that the PSR is inconsistent with the existence of contingent facts.

That would be terrible news for the cosmological argument, for that argument requires both the PSR and the premise that there are contingent things.



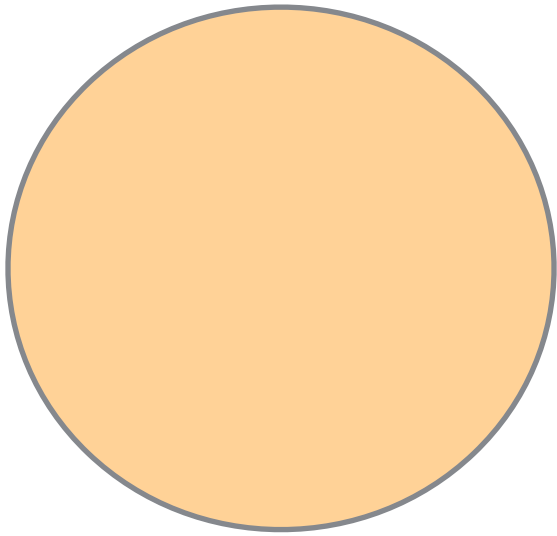
Leibniz's
argument



the
PSR



objections
to the
PSR



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Guides to



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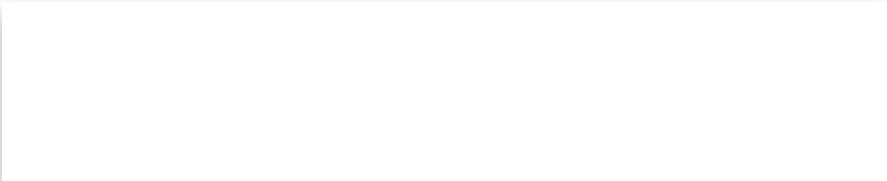
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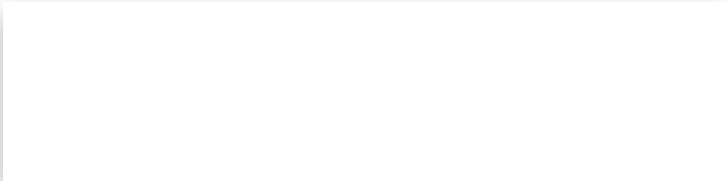
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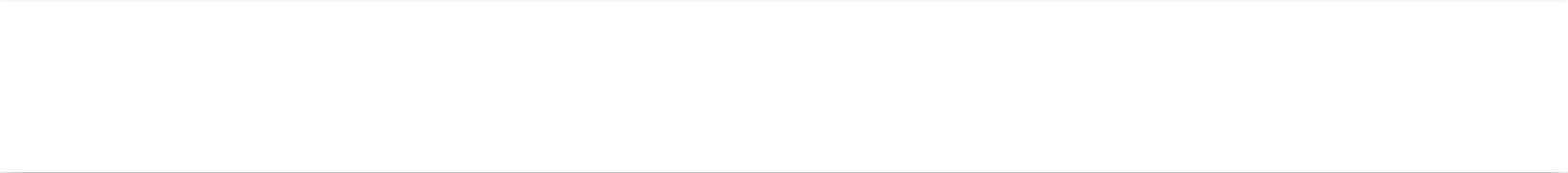


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Notre Dame is India and USC is California

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... we cannot find in any of the individual things, or even in the entire collection and series of things, a sufficient reason for why they exist.

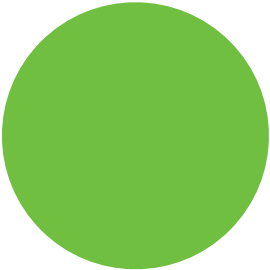
Let us suppose that a book on the elements of geometry has always existed, one copy always made from another. It is obvious that although we can explain a present copy of the book from the previous book from which it was copied, this will never lead us to a complete explanation, no matter how many books back we go, since we can always wonder why there have been such books.

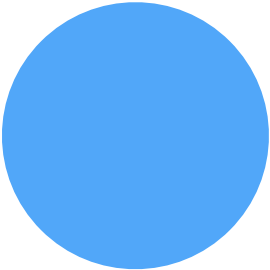
What is true of these books is also true of the different states of the world ... however far back we might go into previous states, we will never find in those states a complete explanation for why there is a world at all, and why it is the way it is.





the
PSR







be Good.

Last time we considered an objection to Aquinas' assumption that if a first

cause exists, then God exists: the objection was that the first cause could

simply be some event, like the Big Bang, which is not a plausible candidate to

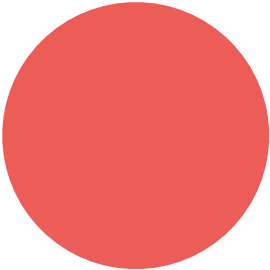


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